

less a time for Rahul to gain a stature equal to that of L.K. Advani.

BAL GOVIND, *Bareilly*

The "heir apparent" cannot substitute credible local leadership no matter how many spartan meals he shares with the Dalits, a fact that Rahul himself seems to have realised. The corollary is that his grooming should be a bottom-up process along with that of a local leadership.

BISHAN SAHAL, *on e-mail*

A certain Sakya prince in the sixth century, fazed by the poverty in his city, could just walk away from power. 'Prince' Rahul, like his mother, does not seem to have that option. For the Congress, his succession is not a matter of his choice, but an inexorable destiny that neither the grand old party nor its reluctant young leader can break away from.

M.H. RAO, *Hyderabad*

No one but only diehard Congress supporters can expect any miracle from the young Gandhi. To expect people to vote for his party on the basis of his personal charm is asking for too much. He alone cannot be blamed for not delivering the goods.

D.B.N. MURTHY, *Bangalore*

Adding Fuel to the Fire

It is very easy to pass on the burden of increasing prices to the consumer ("The Slippery Slope", June 16). Most of the times, the reason for such a step is the inefficiency and lack of accountability of the organisation in question.

Otherwise how is it that

despite inflation, manufacturers of electronic and white goods are able to provide better products continuously at low prices?

RAHESH DUDANI, *Pune*

A Dead Weight

Women today need to maintain an ideal weight through healthy diets and moderate exercises while keeping themselves away from eating disorders like bulimia and anorexia caused by an obsessive

desire to lose weight ("Fat of the Matter", June 16).

A.K. SHARMA, *Chandigarh*

Flawed Pursuit

The Gujar agitation is a reflection of the UPA Government's policy of divide-and-rule ("Tribal War", June 9). It is degrading our democracy. Instead of providing reservations on the basis of caste, such concessions must be based on an economic criteria.

CAJETAN PETER D'SOUZA,

Mumbai

SHOCK OF THE SOUTH



B. K. RAMESH

As the nation grapples with rising inflation, BJP has its hands full with agendas ("BJP on a Roll, Congress on the Ropes", June 9). The way to 7, Race Course Road would become much easier if L.K. Advani can match A.B. Vajpayee's stature and charisma.

C.H. ABHISHEK, *Hyderabad*

BJP's rise in Karnataka is only a one-off case and can in no way reflect the party's standing in peninsular India.

The party won, thanks to the blatant power hungry political machinations of the Gowda father-son duo and an agenda-less lacklustre opposition.

JINU MATHEW, *on e-mail*

The Congress has lost its appeal mainly due to the lack of an able and honest state leader who wields a mass appeal at the grassroot level. It is high time the Congress decentralised the power centre in Delhi and handed over the reins to a suitable state leader.

P.K. SRIVASTAVA, *on e-mail*

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Years Ago in India Today

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The Big Thirst

This summer, a bucket of water was sold for as much as Re 1 in Hamirpur district of Uttar Pradesh. In Biharsharif, the rate was 25 paise a glass. In Gujarat, people in some areas were issued ration cards for water—one of nature's abundant and freely available commodities. Yet, according to official reports, the amount of water wasted in 11 major cities is 726 million litres out of a total supply of 3,000 million litres a day. And despite this, the number of villages in



A Long Wait the country without adequate supply of water is anywhere between 90,000 and 1,60,000 villages. What is worse, only 18 million of the 487 million get safe drinking water. Worms, dead reptiles and other rotting organisms are not uncommon in our pipelines. During monsoons, tap water becomes dirty and turbid. Even in a metropolis, potable water is not available in a sufficient quantity.

—Ashok Mishra